Spending for government “entitlement” programs—money committed by Congress for various programs in past years that is as good as spent before the administration ever gets a shot at writing its budget—accounts for forty-eight percent of federal spending. To many members of Congress, this money is off-limits forever: Once a program gets started, it’s virtually impossible to reduce or stop it. Every one of these programs—most of which were born or expanded enormously during the explosive growth of big government in the 1960s and 1970s—develops a powerful constituency in Congress, and a bureaucracy that is dedicated to preserving it. As I once said in a speech, the tendency of government and its programs to grow are about the nearest thing to eternal life we’ll ever see on this earth.

Presidents can try to rein in spending through their powers of persuasion, but aside from jawboning members of Congress and taking their case to the people, their running room is limited. Over the years, the majority party in Congress (for fifty-five of the last fifty-nine years the Democrats) has devised a bag of tricks that can be very effective in foiling efforts by the executive branch to contain spending. Congress may write a vital piece of legislation, then tack on a pork-barrel rider that throws billions at the pet project of a narrow special-interest group, knowing the president may be forced to accept something he doesn’t want in order to save something he does.

Congress has the power to prevent even as basic a thing as the adoption of a budget for the federal government, and it does so routinely almost every year. Every budget I submitted to Congress outlined spending reductions; if I’d gotten cuts I proposed in 1981, for example, the cumulative deficit between 1982 and 1986 would have been $207 billion less than it was. But I could never get a complete budget passed. Instead, we got a succession of “continuing resolutions” that allowed the government to stay in